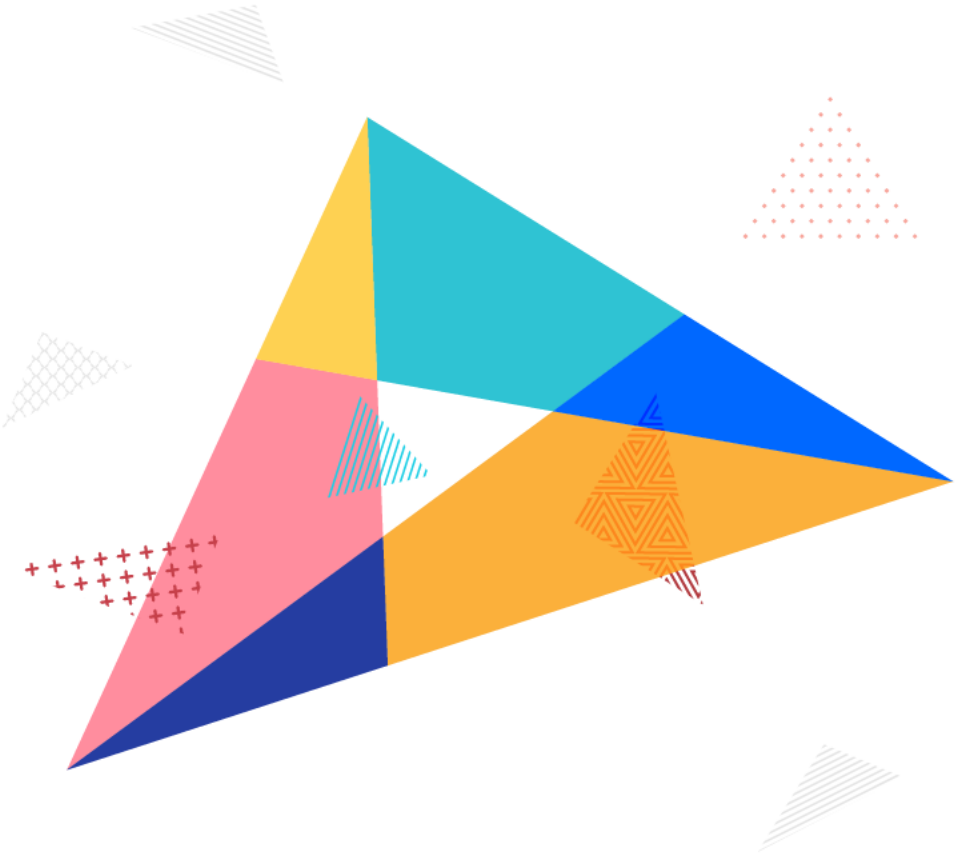
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Adapt Your Leadership Style

Adapt leadership approaches to different situations

Dr. Tony Nguyen

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Session flow

Here's How We'll Spend the Next Three Hours

9:00 – 9:20	Welcome & Frame	Kick-off
9:20 – 9:30	The Leadership Grid	LO1
9:30 – 10:00	Activity #1: Blind Drawing & Debrief	LO1
10:00 – 11:00	Activity #2: Sequence Challenge	LO1 & LO2
11:00 – 11:10	Debrief: Adapting your leadership to your team	LO2 & LO3
11:10 – 11:25	Break	
11:25 – 11:40	Activity #3: Marshmallow Challenge & Debrief	LO3
11:40 – 12:00	Activity #4: Lost at Sea, Debrief & Takeaways	LO4

By the end of the session

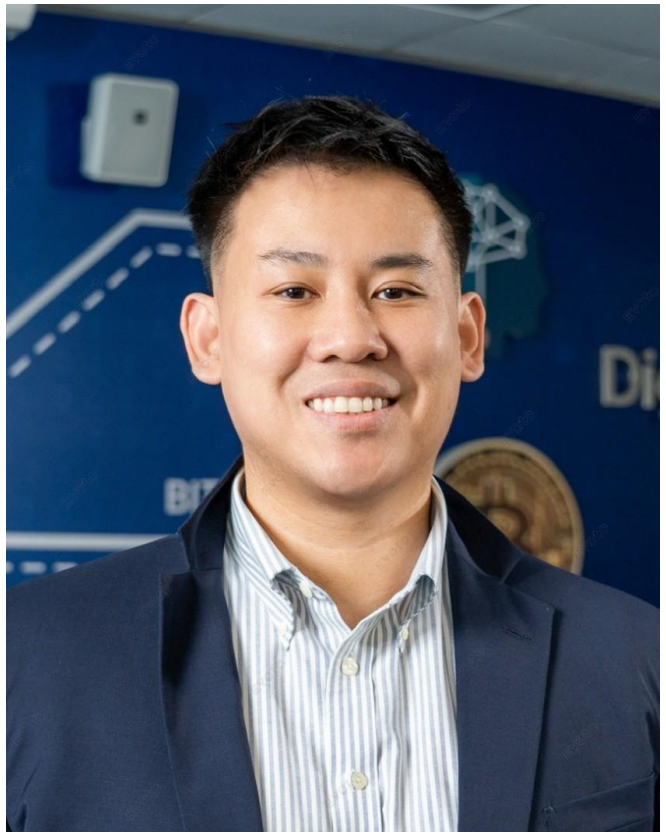
You Will Be Able To...

1. Identify and balance broad leadership behaviors.
2. Assess the fit between leadership approach and situational demands
3. Adapt your behaviors to your followers.
4. Select the appropriate level of employee participation in decision-making.

Welcome!

A quick intro

- Interim Senior Program Manager, Postgraduate Programs, The Business School, RMIT Vietnam
- Ph.D., International Business Administration, Management, Texas A&M International University
- MBA, International Business, University of Houston, Clear Lake



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Very excited for this session

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2026, VOL. 24, NO. 4, 443–460
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RESEARCH ARTICLE

OPEN ACCESS Check for updates

Entrepreneurial leadership affecting knowledge hiding behaviour: the roles of employee envy and peer justice

Giang Hoang[a], Tony Nguyen[a], Tuan Trong Luu[b] and Van Ha Quach[a]

[a]The Business School, RMIT University, Ho Chi Minh, Vietnam; [b]Sunway Business School, Sunway University, Sunway City, Selangor, Malaysia

Psychology Today

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Tony Nguyen Ph.D.
The Human Workplace

WORKPLACE DYNAMICS

Your Office Romance Isn't Just Between Two People

When two coworkers fall for each other, the whole team feels it.

Posted September 7, 2026 | Reviewed by Gary Drevitch



Frame: Who do you credit professionally for your career development so far?

Think of a leader who genuinely helped you grow. What did they do that made them effective for you? (1 minute)

Mini activity #1 (6 mins)

Pair Interviews

How it works

1. Each person share for about 3 minutes while the other listens and takes notes
2. The partner takes notes on the story
3. Then, switch
4. We will share some stories at the workshop level

Some interview questions

1. *Who was the person?*
2. *What did the leader actually do?*
3. *How did this help you?*
4. *Why do you think this was needed at the time?*

Share your partner's journey:

What does "effective" leadership look like?

If we want to adapt our leadership, what can we adapt?

Adapt your leadership

Leadership behaviors: What is it that leaders actually do?

University of Michigan & Ohio State University asked this question in two seminal studies

Task-Oriented

Behaviors that focus on structure, efficiency, and meeting specific goals

People-Oriented

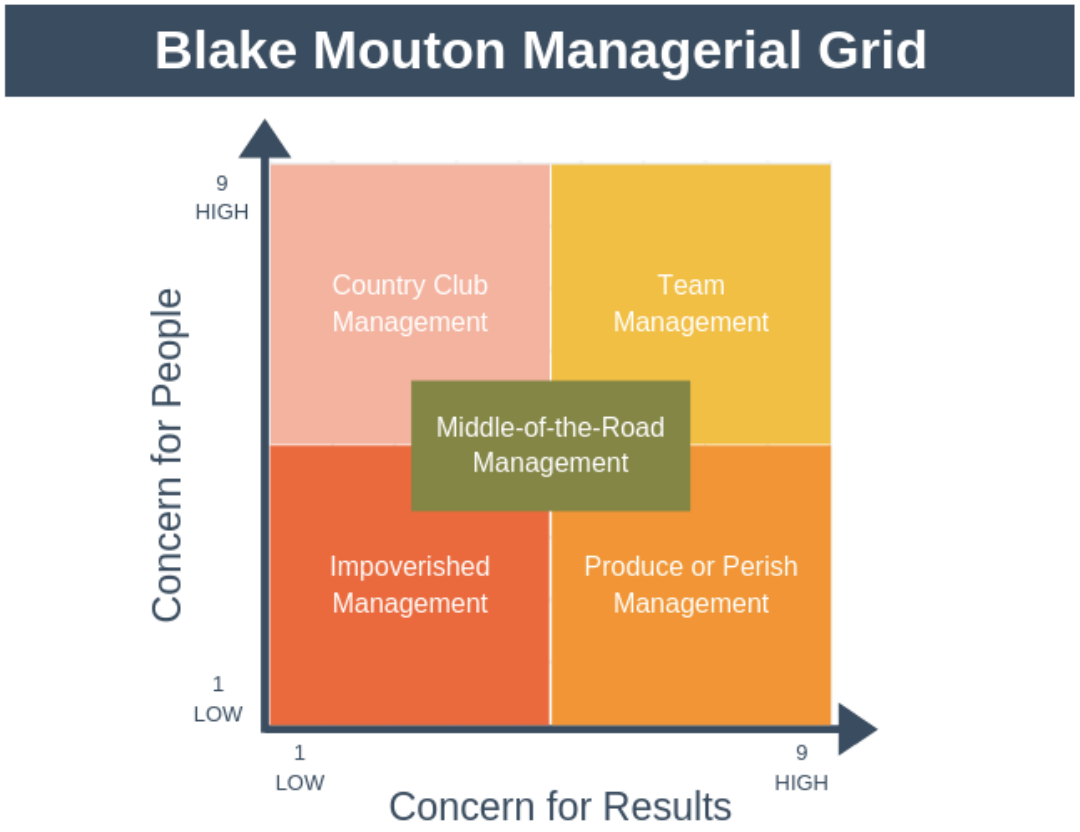
Behaviors that prioritize the follower's well-being, satisfaction, growth & development

Source: Michigan: Katz, Maccoby, & Morse (1950); Katz et al. (1951); Ohio State: Hemphill & Coons (1957); Fleishman (1953)

Leadership Grid

Mini activity #2: Blake and Mouton

- A tool to simply understand your natural leadership style
- Identify yours (5 minutes)
- Reflect and share with us:
  - Do you agree with your results?
  - In which situations could this style help/hurt you?





Activity #1 Blind drawing

We have identified task behavior as one important part of leadership. Let's test what task-focused leadership actually feels like.

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Activity #1 (6 mins)

Blind Drawing Round #1: Test your direction-giving skills

How it works

1. Work in pairs. One person is the **Director** and receives an image. The other is the **Drawer** and cannot see the image.
2. Sit back-to-back
3. Director start giving instructions. Drawer cannot speak!
4. **Don't reveal to each other yet. Please wait for Round #2**

5

IMPORTANT

- *Director may speak.*
- *Drawer **cannot** see the image.*
- *Drawer **cannot** ask questions.*
- *Director **cannot** show the image or physically demonstrate.*

You have 3 minutes

Activity #1 (6 mins)

Blind Drawing Round #2: Test your direction-giving skills

How it works

1. Work in pairs. One person is the **Director** and receives an image. The other is the **Drawer** and cannot see the image.
2. Sit back-to-back
3. Director start giving instructions. Drawer **CAN now** speak!
4. **Don't reveal to each other yet.**

IMPORTANT

- *Director may speak.*
- *Drawer **cannot** see the image.*
- ***Drawer can ask questions**.*
- *Director **cannot** show the image or physically demonstrate.*

You have 3 minutes

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The Big Reveal: Round 1

Discuss with your partners your results

Consider these questions:

As the Director - How clear were the directions, really?

- Where did you assume your partner understood what you meant?
- Which words or instructions seemed clear to you but may not have been clear to them?

As the Drawer- What was it like receiving the direction?

- Which instructions were easy to follow?
- Which instructions could have meant different things?

The Big Reveal: Round 2

Share the results

- What changed when the Drawer could ask for clarification?
- Which questions helped the Director realize that an instruction was unclear or based on an assumption?
- Did the conversation make the task faster, more accurate, or both? Why?

Some key points

- You may not be as clear as you believe you are.
- Clear Direction improves when followers can test, question, and clarify what they have heard.
- Sometimes, direction-giving alone may not be enough.



Activity #2 Sequence Challenge

A three-part group-level experiment.
Three rounds. Same structure.

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Sequence Challenge

Setup for Round #1

1. Select one person at your table to be the leader. The rest of you will be the followers.

2. Leaders, please follow me.

3. Followers, you will receive a hidden card.
   - DO NOT SHOW YOUR CARD.
   - Listen carefully to instructions.
   - You may talk, but do not move at this point.
   - Agree and commit to a final sequence amongst yourselves
   - You may respectfully disagree with the leader, but he/she makes the final decision

Round 1 reflection

Two perspectives on the same communication breakdown.

Leader

When your followers did not respond as expected, what did you assume was happening?

Followers

How did the leader’s direction feel when it did not match your understanding of the task?

Sequence Round 2

You know the process now, but can you trust the situation?

I may have changed something.
I may have given someone misleading information.
Or I may have done nothing.

Work with your group. Do not show your card.

Round 2 reflection

What did the group need when confidence was lower?

Leader

How did you help the group move forward when they had the knowledge, but you did not have the answer?

Followers

When you knew enough to solve the task but were not fully confident, what did you need from your leader?

Sequence Round 3

Work through the sequence using only the rules you receive.

Round 3 reflection

What happened when the leader stopped solving?

Leader

What changed when you stopped trying to solve the problem yourself?

Followers

What was it like knowing exactly what to do while your leader continued directing you?

What changed across the three rounds?

Compare the followers and what they needed from the leader.

Round	Follower condition	What they needed
1	Confident, but unable to complete the real task	Direction and clarity
2	Capable, but less confident	Support and reassurance
3	Capable and confident	Autonomy and space to act

Would one leadership style have worked equally well in all three rounds?

Situational Leadership: diagnose first

Before deciding how to lead, understand the follower's readiness for this task.

Can they do it?

Competence

Will they do it?

Commitment and confidence

Competence and Commitment are per task, not a permanent label – and will drifts over time, so keep re-checking in your regular 1:1s.

Map the rounds together

Follower need determines leadership response.



The four leadership responses

Adapt direction and support to follower readiness.

S1 **Directing**

High direction, lower support

S2 **Coaching**

High direction, high support

S3 **Supporting**

Lower direction, high support

S4 **Delegating**

Lower direction, lower support

Your preferred style matters less than the follower’s need for this specific task.



What was unrealistic about the sequence activity?



Whew- Take a 15-Minute Break

When you come back, you will experience the challenges of adapting to different members within a team

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Activity #3 Marshmallow Challenge

So how do you lead when teams are made up by people of different readiness levels?

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The challenge

Build the tallest freestanding structure with the entire marshmallow on top.

The Kit

- 20 sticks of uncooked spaghetti
- 1 yard of masking tape
- 1 yard of string
- 1 standard-size marshmallow

The Goal

Tallest structure
Freestanding
Entire marshmallow on top

No hanging, no taping to walls, no external support.

Teams of 3 or 4

Each team has one leader and followers with different limitations.

1

Leader

Can see and talk
Cannot touch materials

2

Restricted follower

Can touch and talk
Cannot look

3

Advisor follower

Can see and talk
Cannot touch

4

Builder follower

Can see, talk, and touch
Relatively unrestricted

You will be assigned the exact role mix for each team size.

The hidden leadership challenge

The tallest tower is not the only test.

Can you help everyone contribute productively and feel included?

Some people will be easier to involve.
Some will require more effort, communication, and adaptation.

A leader’s job is not only to adapt. It is to create contribution despite limitations.

Marshmallow debrief

Different people can need different leadership at the same time.

Did everyone need the same type or amount of leadership?

Who became easiest to rely on?

Who became easiest to ignore?

What helped everyone contribute?

Real teams have mixed readiness, different constraints, and different contribution needs.



Activity #4 Lost at Sea

SLT gives us a structured way to adjust our behaviors to match our employees

A relevant question is: How much involvement should employees have in decision-making?

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Vroom–Yetton–Jago Model

Five decision styles available to a leader

The Vroom–Yetton–Jago model suggests that the best way to make a decision depends on the situation, including the importance of the decision and the value of input from others.

DECISION STYLE	DEFINITION	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
AI Autocratic I	Manager makes the decision alone.	**"I will decide."** You make the decision using the information you have.
AII Autocratic II	Manager asks for information from subordinates but makes the decision alone. Subordinates may or may not be informed about what the situation is.	**"Give me your input, I will decide."** You seek individual input, then decide.
CI Consultative I	Manager shares the situation with individual subordinates and asks for information and evaluation. Subordinates do not meet as a group, and the manager alone makes the decision.	**"Let's discuss (one-to-one), I will decide."** You consult individuals, then decide.
CII Consultative II	Manager and subordinates meet as a group to discuss the situation, but the manager makes the decision.	**"Let's discuss as a group, I will decide."** You discuss with the team, then decide.
GII Group II	Manager and subordinates meet as a group to discuss the situation, and the group makes the decision.	**"Let's discuss and decide together."** You facilitate a group discussion and reach a shared decision.

A = autocratic | C = consultative | G = group

The right decision style depends on the situation.
Consider factors such as decision importance, time pressure, quality of information, and the value of others' input.

Wrap-up

Remember These Four Things Before You Go.



- Diagnose before you lead
- Clarity is not the same as talking more
- Different people need different things at different time
- Match participation to the decision

Academic sources cited in this deck

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